entire Pakistan team to dedicate a not-so-original Bollywood soundtrack to him!

But to me, Lara's wicket was a big deal because I was still in my teens, he was twenty-seven, averaging over 47 in ODIs, and had played more than a hundred matches. Basically, he was at his peak and I was a rookie, only on my second international tour. And we were playing against each other at the prestigious Sydney Cricket Ground.

I remember charging in. I remember him volleying it back to me, low. I remember going for it. The rest was just instinct and automated hand–eye coordination. But I think I figured out there, mid-dive, before I hit the turf, that we now had the match in our grasp. I was right. What a rush it was! What a way to get the greatest batsman of the era!

So there I was, in Australia and on a roll. That crazy 102 in Kenya. A killer series Down Under. In a few months, I'd graduated from skirmishing in the locker room with Zeeshan Pervaiz to claiming Brian Lara's scalp. Life had changed. Forever.

The best bit about my life in those early days wasn't the cricket, though. It was returning home. The crowds at the airport, the love and affection I'd get the minute I landed till the time I reached home, made me realize whom I was playing for: my people, my family. Their happiness was all that mattered.

At the time, I hadn't begun looking at things from a commercial perspective. But all of a sudden, there were a lot of sponsors interested in me. Of course, there was plenty of attention from all quarters – especially women – but all I was really interested in was helping my family, especially my father, recover from the terrible loss he had suffered. Financially and emotionally, I wanted to be there for him. He'd been a successful man all his life and a financial loss of that stature had dealt a big blow to his self-confidence. So I wanted to make sure my parents and siblings had two square meals a day, and that my father recovered his sense of self-belief and independence. That's all.

That's why I was playing cricket – two square meals a day and some self-respect.

That's all one needs anyway.